

CYBERSECURITY

Beginner study plan • Exam preparation • Official clickable resources

Your goal

Build the fundamentals, study in a clear order, practise safely, and sit the official certification exam only when you are ready.

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Important: Course duration and exam details can change. This guide gives a suggested learning plan; the current Cisco exam page and blueprint are the final source of truth.

1. Start here: enrol and verify the exam

Use Cisco's official resources first. Avoid paying third-party sites for a certificate that is not the actual Cisco certification.

A. Cisco Networking Academy — Junior Cybersecurity Analyst Career Path

A structured, self-paced learning path that Cisco recommends for preparing for entry-level cybersecurity knowledge. Create a free account and search for the exact course name. Follow the modules in the current course layout.

- [Open Cisco Networking Academy](#)
- [Cisco CCST exams and training hub](#)

B. Official CCST Cybersecurity exam page

Use this page to verify the current exam code, price, duration, topic outline and registration instructions before booking. Prices may vary with region, taxes or currency conversion.

- [Open official CCST Cybersecurity exam details](#)

C. Cisco Networking Academy cybersecurity courses

If you want shorter topic-based lessons alongside the career path, explore Cisco's free cybersecurity course catalogue and choose beginner-level content.

- [Browse Cisco Networking Academy](#)

Suggested weekly routine

Time	Activity
35 minutes	Study one course lesson and take short notes.
15 minutes	Revise terms and explain them in your own words.
10 minutes	Answer practice questions or review mistakes.

2. Suggested 16-week study plan

Plan for about one hour a day, six days a week. This is a suggested pace, not an official Cisco timetable. If a topic is difficult, repeat it before moving on.

Weeks 1–2 — Security fundamentals

Study: CIA triad (confidentiality, integrity, availability); authentication vs authorisation; least privilege; assets, threats, vulnerabilities and risk; malware; phishing and social engineering.

Checkpoint: Explain the CIA triad and distinguish a threat from a vulnerability.

Weeks 3–4 — Networking essentials

Study: LAN/WAN; switches and routers; IPv4 and IPv6 basics; MAC addresses; subnet masks; default gateways; DNS; DHCP; TCP vs UDP; common ports.

Checkpoint: Use ipconfig and nslookup; explain what a gateway and DNS server do.

Weeks 5–6 — Threats and attacks

Study: Phishing, credential theft, ransomware, denial of service, spoofing, password attacks and common attack surfaces. Learn basic prevention and reporting.

Checkpoint: Describe a likely attack and suggest safe defensive measures.

Weeks 7–8 — Endpoint and operating-system security

Study: Updates and patching; host firewall; antivirus/endpoint protection; accounts and permissions; secure configuration; backups; basic Windows logs.

Checkpoint: Explain how to reduce endpoint risk and find basic system information.

Weeks 9–10 — Network security and defensive controls

Study: Segmentation concepts; secure protocols; firewalls; access control; VPN concepts; wireless security; monitoring and logging.

Checkpoint: Explain what a firewall does and why network segmentation helps.

Weeks 11–12 — Vulnerabilities, risk and security operations

Study: Vulnerability vs exploit; risk likelihood and impact; asset inventory; patch prioritisation; alert triage; security policies; incident response stages.

Checkpoint: Prioritise a simple vulnerability scenario and outline response steps.

Weeks 13–14 — Hands-on review

Study: Repeat labs, practise interpreting command output, review course activities and make flashcards for terms you confuse.

Checkpoint: Complete practical tasks without relying on step-by-step instructions.

Weeks 15–16 — Exam readiness

Study: Review the current official exam topic outline; revisit weak areas; take reputable practice questions; review explanations for every mistake.

Checkpoint: Explain each exam topic in your own words and consistently perform well on practice sets.

3. Safe practice checklist

Practise on your own computer or a lab where you have permission. Do not run scans, install tools or test security controls on an employer's production network without explicit authorisation.

Done	Exercise	What it teaches
■	Run <code>ipconfig /all</code> on your Windows computer.	IP address, gateway, DNS and adapter configuration.
■	Run <code>nslookup example.com</code> .	Basic DNS lookup behaviour.
■	Run <code>ping 127.0.0.1</code> .	IPv4 loopback testing; this does not test the physical network.
■	Review Windows Update and Windows Security settings.	Updates, endpoint protection and host firewall basics.
■	Identify a sample phishing message from a trusted training exercise.	Spot suspicious links, sender mismatch, urgency and unexpected attachments.
■	Write a one-page incident report for a fictional malware alert.	Clear documentation, evidence preservation and escalation.

Useful study habits

- Keep a glossary of security terms with one-line definitions and one example each.
- Use spaced revision: revisit notes after one day, one week and one month.
- For every wrong practice answer, write why the correct option is correct and why your choice was wrong.
- Explain concepts out loud as if teaching a beginner; this reveals gaps in understanding.

4. Exam readiness and booking

Do not book the exam just because you have finished watching lessons. Use the official exam page to confirm current requirements and test availability.

- I completed the current recommended learning path or equivalent study.
- I can explain every topic listed in the current official exam blueprint.
- I understand basic networking: IP, DNS, DHCP, TCP/UDP, ports, switches, routers and firewalls.
- I can distinguish threats, vulnerabilities, risks and security controls.
- I understand endpoint protection, access control, patching and incident response basics.
- I have reviewed every incorrect practice answer and revisited weak topics.
- I checked the current exam code, price, duration, registration method and ID requirements.

Book only through the official route

The official Cisco exam page is the best place to confirm current exam information and follow the approved registration instructions. Be cautious of websites promising a certificate without the official exam.

- [CCST Cybersecurity exam page](#)

Budget and validity reminders

Cisco's listed exam fee has been US\$125, but fees, taxes, exchange rates and availability can change. Confirm the price before booking. Check Cisco's current certification policy for validity and renewal details.

After passing

Save your official credential record, add the certification to your CV and professional profile, and continue building practical skills. A certification can support job applications but does not guarantee a role or promotion.

Your first action today: open Cisco Networking Academy, create an account, search for “Junior Cybersecurity Analyst Career Path,” and start the first module.

Clickable official resources

- [Cisco Networking Academy](#)
- [CCST Cybersecurity official exam page](#)
- [Cisco support technician exams and training](#)